3 John

Key Notes, Cross-References, and Messianic Connections (WEB)

The shortest book in the Bible. In the Greek, just over two hundred words.

A personal letter from the elder to his friend Gaius.

And it is about three men.

Gaius, who opens his door to traveling brothers he has never met, and sends them on their way well.

Diotrephes, who loves to be first. Who will not receive the elder's letter, will not receive the brothers, and throws out anyone who does.

And Demetrius, who has a good testimony from everyone, and from the truth itself.

In between, a line every parent knows. I have no greater joy than to hear that my children walk in truth.

And a line every believer needs. Do not imitate what is evil, but what is good.

Then the elder puts down his pen. I would rather talk face to face.

Peace to you. Greet the friends by name.

This is not just history.

This is a mirror.

And tonight, we let the Word fill us.

3 JOHN - Walking in Truth, a Man Who Loved to Be First, and Greet the Friends by Name

Key Notes

- 3 John is the shortest book in the Bible by word count, just over two hundred words in Greek. It would have fit on a single sheet of papyrus (3 John 1:1-14).
- Gaius was a common name; there are several in the New Testament. This one is known only from this letter, and the elder calls him beloved four times (3 John 1:1, 1:2, 1:5, 1:11).
- “I pray that you may prosper in all things and be healthy, even as your soul prospers.” This was a normal way to open a letter in that world - I hope you are well. It is a prayer for a friend, not a promise that faith guarantees wealth (3 John 1:2).
- Notice the measure, though: even as your soul prospers. John wants Gaius’s outward life to be as healthy as his inner life already is. Few of us would want that prayer prayed over us honestly (3 John 1:2).
- Prosperity in Scripture is tied to the word: meditate on this book of the instructions day and night, and then you will make your way prosperous (3 John 1:2, Joshua 1:8, Psalm 1:3).
- “Your truth, even as you walk in truth.” Truth here is not only what Gaius believes. It is how he walks (3 John 1:3, Psalm 26:3).
- “I have no greater joy than this, to hear about my children walking in truth.” The elder’s spiritual children, those who came to faith through him. Proverbs: the father of the righteous has great joy (3 John 1:4, Proverbs 23:24).
- “For those who are brothers and strangers.” Gaius welcomed traveling believers he had never met. The Torah commanded it: love the foreigner, for you were foreigners in Egypt (3 John 1:5, Deuteronomy 10:19).
- Abraham ran out to meet three strangers, washed their feet and fed them, and found he was entertaining messengers of Yahweh (3 John 1:5, Genesis 18:2-5, Hebrews 13:2).
- “Send them forward on their journey in a way worthy of God.” To send forward meant to supply them with what they needed for the next stage - food, money, sometimes a companion (3 John 1:6).
- “For the sake of the Name they went out.” Just the Name - no need to say whose. Malachi: from the rising of the sun my name is great among the nations (3 John 1:7, Malachi 1:11).
- “Taking nothing from the Gentiles.” They would not accept support from the unbelievers they were reaching, so that no one could say they were selling the message (3 John 1:7).
- “That we may be fellow workers for the truth.” The one who houses the messenger shares in the message. It is the reverse of 2 John, where welcoming a deceiver made you a partner in his evil (3 John 1:8, 2 John 1:11).

- “Diotrephes, who loves to be first among them.” One Greek word: he loves first place. Pride, named in a single word. Moses, by contrast, was more humble than any man on the earth (3 John 1:9, Numbers 12:3).
- Diotrephes would not receive the elder’s letter. He did not argue doctrine. The problem the letter names is not what he believed but what he loved - being first (3 John 1:9).
- Four charges against him: he slanders the elder with wicked words, refuses the brothers, forbids others to receive them, and throws out of the assembly those who do. Pride always ends up putting people out (3 John 1:10).
- “If I come, I will call attention to his deeds.” The elder does not gossip about him in the dark. He promises to address it openly, in person (3 John 1:10).
- “Don’t imitate that which is evil, but that which is good.” People become like whoever they watch. The psalm: depart from evil, and do good (3 John 1:11, Psalm 34:14).
- “He who does evil hasn’t seen God.” Not has not heard about God - has not seen Him. Seeing God changes how a person treats people (3 John 1:11).
- Demetrius has the testimony of all, of the truth itself, and of the elder. Three witnesses, as the Torah requires. He may have carried the letter (3 John 1:12, Deuteronomy 19:15).
- “I am unwilling to write to you with ink and pen.” Almost the same words that close 2 John. The elder would rather sit across the table (3 John 1:13, 2 John 1:12).
- “We will speak face to face” - again literally mouth to mouth, as Yahweh spoke with Moses (3 John 1:14, Numbers 12:8).
- “Peace be to you” is shalom, the greeting the risen Lord gave in the locked room (3 John 1:14, John 20:19).
- “Greet the friends by name.” Not the brothers, here - the friends. And by name. The good shepherd calls his own sheep by name (3 John 1:14, John 10:3).

Key Cross-References (WEB)

Topic	References
You Will Make Your Way Prosperous	3 John 1:2 • Joshua 1:8 • Psalm 1:3
I Have Walked in Your Truth	3 John 1:3 • Psalm 26:3 • 1 Kings 2:4
No Greater Joy	3 John 1:4 • Proverbs 23:24-25 • Proverbs 10:1
Love the Foreigner	3 John 1:5 • Deuteronomy 10:19 • Genesis 18:2-5
For the Sake of the Name	3 John 1:7 • Malachi 1:11 • Acts 5:41
The Humblest Man on Earth	3 John 1:9 • Numbers 12:3 • Proverbs 16:18
Depart From Evil, and Do Good	3 John 1:11 • Psalm 34:14 • Psalm 37:27
Greet Them by Name	3 John 1:14 • John 10:3 • Exodus 33:12

Messianic Connections

Connection	References
Beautiful Feet That Bring Good News	3 John 1:8 • Isaiah 52:7
The Name Praised From the Rising of the Sun	3 John 1:7 • Psalm 113:3 • Exodus 3:15
Mouth to Mouth	3 John 1:14 • Numbers 12:8 • Psalm 17:15
Peace Be to You	3 John 1:14 • Isaiah 9:6 • Numbers 6:26

For Further Study

Credible external commentary that expounds on this chapter in a way consistent with a Torah-honoring, Messianic reading of the text:

- Enduring Word - 3 John Commentary (David Guzik) - verse by verse through following good examples
- BibleProject - 1-3 John Overview - a short video on the three letters of John
- Precept Austin - 3 John Commentaries - verse by verse notes and word studies

3 John 1 - Opening Intro

Third John is the shortest book in the whole Bible. In the Greek it is just over two hundred words. You could read it out loud in about a minute.

And it is a personal letter, from the elder - John - to his friend Gaius. And it is about three men.

The first is Gaius. And John starts by praying for him. Beloved, I pray that you prosper in all things and be in health, just as your soul prospers.

Now people have built whole ministries on that verse, saying God promises you money and health. That is not what it is. It is how people started letters back then - I hope you are well. It is a friend praying for a friend.

But look at the measure. As your soul prospers. John is saying: Gaius, I hope your body and your life are doing as well as your soul is. How many of us would want that prayer prayed over us? If my outside matched my inside - would I be healthy, or sick?

And then: I have no greater joy than to hear that my children are walking in truth.

Every parent in this room knows that one. And every spiritual father too.

And Gaius has been doing something faithful. Traveling brothers - preachers going from town to town - came to his door. He had never met them. And he took them in, and fed them, and sent them on their way with what they needed.

That is the Torah. Love the stranger, because you were strangers in Egypt. That is Abraham running out of his tent to wash the feet of three men he did not know - and finding out he was hosting messengers of Yahweh.

And John says they went out for the sake of the Name. Just the Name. He does not even have to say whose.

And when you support people like that, John says, you become fellow workers for the truth.

Then the second man. Diotrephes. And John describes him in one Greek word: he loves to be first.

That is it. That is his whole problem. He does not have a false doctrine. He has a pride problem.

And watch what pride does. He would not receive John's letter. He spreads wicked words about John. He will not take in the traveling brothers. He stops other people from taking them in. And then he throws them out of the church.

Pride always ends with somebody being put out.

And John says: if I come, I will bring it up. Not behind his back. To his face.

Then the turn. Beloved, do not imitate what is evil. Imitate what is good. The one who does good is from God. The one who does evil has not seen God.

You become like whoever you watch. Do not watch Diotrephes.

And then the third man. Demetrius. He has a good testimony from everybody, and from the truth itself, and from John. Three witnesses, just like the Torah requires.

And then John puts down his pen. I have a lot to tell you, but I do not want to write it with ink. I hope to see you soon, and we will talk face to face.

Peace to you. The friends greet you. Greet the friends by name.

By name. Not a mass email. Every one of them, by name. That is how the Good Shepherd does it.

Before we read - three men. One opened his door. One loved first place. One had a good name with everybody. Which one would the people around you say you are?

3 John 1:1-14 (WEB)

1 The elder to Gaius the beloved, whom I love in truth.

2 Beloved, I pray that you may prosper in all things and be healthy, even as your soul prospers.[1]

3 For I rejoiced greatly, when brothers came and testified about your truth, even as you walk in truth.[2]

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[1] **Cross-Reference:** Joshua 1:8 • Psalm 1:3 - *meditate on the book of the instructions day and night and you will make your way prosperous, and whatever he does shall prosper*

4 I have no greater joy than this, to hear about my children walking in truth.[3]

5 Beloved, you do a faithful work in whatever you accomplish for those who are brothers and strangers.[4]

6 They have testified about your love before the assembly. You will do well to send them forward on their journey in a way worthy of God,

7 because for the sake of the Name they went out, taking nothing from the Gentiles.[5,6]

8 We therefore ought to receive such, that we may be fellow workers for the truth.[7]

9 I wrote to the assembly, but Diotrephes, who loves to be first among them, doesn't accept what we say.[8]

10 Therefore if I come, I will call attention to his deeds which he does, unjustly accusing us with wicked words. Not content with this, neither does he himself receive the brothers, and those who would, he forbids and throws out of the assembly.

11 Beloved, don't imitate that which is evil, but that which is good. He who does good is of God. He who does evil hasn't seen God.[9]

12 Demetrius has the testimony of all, and of the truth itself; yes, we also testify, and you know that our testimony is true.[10]

13 I had many things to write to you, but I am unwilling to write to you with ink and pen;

14 but I hope to see you soon, and we will speak face to face. Peace be to you. The friends greet you. Greet the friends by name.[11,12,13]

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[2] **Cross-Reference:** Psalm 26:3 • 1 Kings 2:4 - *I have walked in your truth, and children who walk before me in truth with all their heart*

[3] **Cross-Reference:** Proverbs 23:24-25 • Proverbs 10:1 - *the father of the righteous has great joy, and a wise son makes a glad father*

[4] **Cross-Reference:** Deuteronomy 10:19 • Genesis 18:2-5 - *love the foreigner, for you were foreigners in Egypt, and Abraham running to welcome three strangers*

[5] **Cross-Reference:** Malachi 1:11 • Acts 5:41 - *my name is great among the nations, and rejoicing to suffer dishonor for the Name*

[6] **Messianic Connection:** Psalm 113:3 • Exodus 3:15 - *from the rising of the sun Yahweh's name is to be praised, and this is my name forever*

[7] **Messianic Connection:** Isaiah 52:7 - *how beautiful are the feet of him who brings good news and publishes peace*

[8] **Cross-Reference:** Numbers 12:3 • Proverbs 16:18 - *Moses more humble than all the men on the earth, and pride goes before destruction*

[9] **Cross-Reference:** Psalm 34:14 • Psalm 37:27 - *depart from evil and do good, seek peace and pursue it*

[10] **Cross-Reference:** Deuteronomy 19:15 - *every matter established at the mouth of two or three witnesses*

[11] **Messianic Connection:** Numbers 12:8 • Psalm 17:15 - *with Moses I speak mouth to mouth, and I shall be satisfied seeing your form*

[12] **Messianic Connection:** Isaiah 9:6 • Numbers 6:26 - *the Prince of Peace, and Yahweh lift up his face toward you and give you peace*

[13] **Cross-Reference:** John 10:3 • Exodus 33:12 - *the shepherd calls his own sheep by name, and I know you by name*

Major Themes in 3 John

- A friend’s prayer, not a promise of wealth
- An outward life measured by the health of the soul
- Truth as a way of walking
- No greater joy than children walking in truth
- A door opened to strangers
- Going out for the sake of the Name
- Fellow workers for the truth by supporting its messengers
- A man who loved to be first
- Pride that ends by putting people out
- Correction promised openly, not whispered
- Imitating the good, not the evil
- Doing evil as evidence of never having seen God
- A good testimony from all, from the truth, and from the elder
- Words better spoken face to face
- Friends greeted by name

Benediction

Let this be the word that goes before us tonight:

May our souls prosper, and may our lives match our souls.

May we walk in the truth and not only hold it.

May our children walk in truth and give us that joy.

May our doors be open to the brothers we have never met.

May we send others on their way in a manner worthy of God.

May we go out for the sake of the Name.

May we be fellow workers for the truth.

May we never love first place.

May we never put out those He has sent.

May we imitate what is good.

May we see God, and live like it.

May we have a good testimony from all, and from the truth itself.

May we greet one another by name.

May every promise He has spoken over us stand up, come forth, and manifest in its appointed time.

Amen.